THEORY · SIMULINK · WEEK 1

First-order systems and your first Simulink model

First-order systems

Many systems relax towards an equilibrium at a rate proportional to how far they are from it:

$$\tau \frac{dy}{dt} = y_\infty - y$$

τ is the **time constant** and y_∞ the final value. Coil currents, heat in a plasma after the heating switches off (energy confinement time τ_E), and a thermocouple tracking a wall temperature all look like this.

For a constant y_∞ and $y(0) = y_0$, separating variables gives

$$y(t) = y_\infty + (y_0 - y_\infty)\, e^{-t/\tau}$$

Useful landmarks: after $t = \tau$ the system has covered $1 - e^{-1} \approx 63.2\,\%$ of the way; after 3τ, 95 %; after 5τ, 99.3 %. Reading off the 63.2 % time is the standard way to *measure* τ from data.

To use this on any linear first-order ODE, divide by the coefficient of y and match terms against the form above: that gives you τ and y_∞ in terms of the physical parameters.

Simulink: an ODE as a loop of blocks

Simulink doesn't solve equations you write down; it integrates signals. The recipe for any ODE:

1. Write it as $\frac{dx}{dt} = (\text{something built from } x \text{ and inputs})$.
2. Put an **Integrator** block in the middle. Its *output* is x; its *input* must be dx/dt.
3. Build dx/dt out of x (fed back from the integrator output) and the inputs, using **Sum** and **Gain** blocks.

Minimal example (not today's model): a falling ball, $\ddot{z} = -g$, $z(0) = h_0$, $\dot{z}(0) = 0$.

```
[Constant: -g] --> [Integrator, IC 0] --v--> [Integrator, IC h0] --z--> [To Workspace: z_out]
```

Two integrators in a row turn acceleration into velocity, then position. A first-order ODE needs one integrator plus a feedback path.

Blocks you need today (Library Browser, or click the canvas and type the name):

Block	Library	What it does
Step	Sources	jumps from *Initial value* to *Final value* at *Step time*
Sum	Math Operations	adds inputs; *List of signs* `+-` gives $u_1 - u_2$
Gain	Math Operations	multiplies by a constant (can be an expression like `1/L`)
Integrator	Continuous	$x(t) = x_0 + \int_0^t u\, dt'$
To Workspace	Sinks	stores the signal in the simulation output

Drag from a block's output port to an input port to connect; to branch an existing line, drag from the line while holding Ctrl (Windows) or right-click-drag. Ctrl+R rotates, Ctrl+I flips a block, which keeps feedback paths tidy.

Parameters and running from a script

Block parameters can be any MATLAB expression in the workspace, e.g. a Gain of `k/m`. If `k` isn't defined when you press Run, you get an "undefined variable" error. Either run your parameter script first, or put its name in *Model Settings → Model Properties → Callbacks → InitFcn* so it runs automatically on every simulation.

From a script:

```
params;                                  % define the variables
out = sim('ball');                       % run ball.slx with its saved settings
plot(out.z_out.Time, out.z_out.Data)     % Timeseries: .Time and .Data
out2 = sim('ball', 'Solver', 'ode1', 'FixedStep', '0.1');  % override solver for one run
```

`sim` returns a `SimulationOutput` object; each To Workspace variable is a field of it. Solver options passed to `sim` are strings.

Solvers: ode45 vs ode1

Simulink advances the integrators with a numerical ODE solver, set in *Model Settings → Solver*.

- **Variable-step `ode45`** (default): a 4th/5th-order Runge–Kutta method that picks its own step to meet a tolerance. Accurate, but it may take few, large steps on smooth curves, so plots look jagged. *Max step size* caps the step.
- **Fixed-step `ode1`**: plain explicit Euler with step h, exactly the method from the tritium exercise. Everything there about order and stability applies here.

Refresher on stability. For $dy/dt = -\lambda y$, one Euler step multiplies y by $(1 - \lambda h)$. For $\tau\, dy/dt = y_\infty - y$, the deviation $y - y_\infty$ obeys exactly such an equation. Work out what plays the role of λ, and the tritium THEORY tells you where oscillation and blow-up start.

Tips and pitfalls

- **Step block default step time is 1 s**, not 0. Forgetting to change it shifts your whole response by a second.
- **Sum block sign order** matches the input ports top to bottom. Check which port gets the feedback.
- **Jagged ode45 plot?** That's the solver taking big steps, not an error. Set *Max step size* or *Refine factor*.
- **Units:** H/Ω = s. Check that your τ comes out in seconds and your current in amperes before trusting the plot.